

Multi-racial organization says it will present report to school board on needs, equity issues

BY TIM FUNK
Staff Writer

A multi-racial grass-roots group representing more than 40 Mecklenburg County churches kicked off a campaign Sunday to

numbers of low-income students don't lose out under Charlotte/Mecklenburg Schools' new student assignment plan.

About 320 members of HELP - Helping Empower Local People - gathered at Greater Providence Baptist Church to go over the plans for Project Flood Light, which will audit the needs of 40 of the more than 137 public schools in Charlotte/Mecklenburg, then present them in a report to the school board.

HELP team members visiting

7B | A complete list of schools and churches involved in HELP's evaluations.

the schools will be especially alert to any "equity gaps" that may exist between older schools that serve a significant percentage of lower-income families and schools in more affluent - usually suburban - areas.

"We'll be looking at books and at how well the classrooms are lit and whether there are any rusty

UNCC SCIENTISTS TRACK NIGHT CREATURES



DAVID T. FOSTER III - STAFF PHOTOS

UNC Charlotte ornithologist Rob Bierregaard (left) and graduate student Eric Harrold (right, rear) show a young barred owl to a group along Berkeley Avenue in Dilworth.

Owls discover the city, do well in the rat race

'Working relationship' with barred owls will compare how they do

BY BRUCE HENDERSON
Staff Writer

Berkeley Babs perches at dusk near the top of a white oak in Latta Park, unflappable above the excited chatter of her human neighbors.

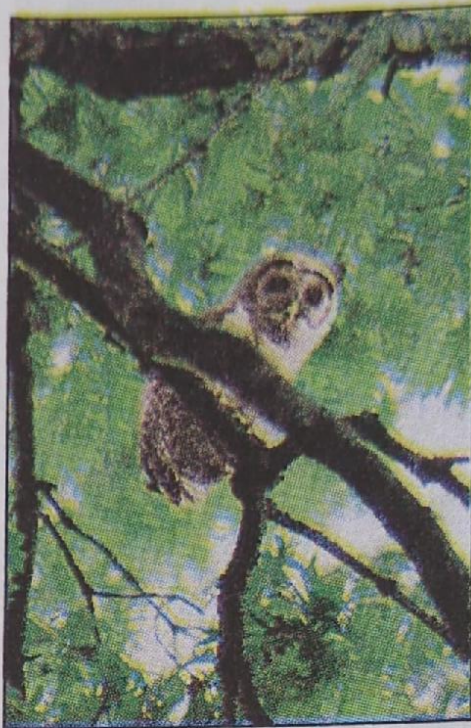
Babs, a barred owl, is part of a backyard science project under way this spring. How, researchers from UNC Charlotte want to know, can woodland predators with a 42-inch wingspan survive in thoroughly civilized Dilworth?

Pretty well, at first glance.

Barred owls are among the wildlife - including deer, foxes and coyotes - that seem undaunted by people.

"You can't swing a dead rat in Charlotte without hitting one," says Rob Bierregaard, the ornithologist guiding the research. "And if you don't hit a barred owl, you hit a Cooper's hawk."

Research sponsored by the Carolina Raptor Center, using a \$4,000 grant from the Foundation



A young barred owl looks down from a tree in Latta Park on Tuesday evening.

for the Carolinas, aims to find out why.

Bierregaard and graduate student Eric Harrold trapped 15 barred owls, nine in the city and six in rural areas. Luring them with a boom-box recording of owl songs, they attached tiny 10-gram radio transmitters to the birds in little backpacks.

Every couple of evenings now, Harrold slings a black receiver over his shoulder and picks up a

Barred Owls

Body: Stocky with round head, broad wings and short tail

Plumage: Brown with streaked belly, dark eyes, yellow beak

Length: 21 inches

Wingspan: 42 inches

Weight: 1.6 pounds (females are larger)

Habitat: Lives in wooded areas, hunts rodents.

Voice: Expressive hoot ("Who-cooks-for-you, who-cooks-for-you-all.")

Source: The Sibley Guide to Birds

hand-held antenna to track each bird's location. The occasional gift of a mouse helps the researchers get close.

"I call it a working relationship," Harrold says.

Their mission is to learn how

SEE WH000 | 48